Program Overview: "Through the Bible in 12 Months"

A children's and youth Sunday school program for ages 4–17 Purpose Church Kids & Youth Ministry

1. Vision & Goals

> "Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105, NIV)

Our goal is for every child, from age 4 to 17, to:

1. **Understand** the Bible's one big story, from Genesis to Revelation, in the simplest words possible.
2. **Memorize** all 66 books of the Bible, in order, by section.
3. **Spell and read** the name of every book (each age at its own level).
4. **Meet Jesus** on every page. The whole Bible points to Him.
5. **Love God's Word** because Sunday school is fun: games, coloring, songs, trivia, crafts and videos.

The One Big Story (teach this every phase)

The Bible is **one big story about God rescuing His people and making everything new**. We use five words, each with a hand motion, that kids repeat all year:

Word	Hand motion	Meaning
CREATION	Hands make a big circle (the world)	God made everything good.
FALL	Hands drop down fast	People chose sin and broke the world.
PROMISE	Pinky-promise with your own hands	God promised a Rescuer.
JESUS	Point to palms (nail marks)	Jesus came, died and rose again to save us.
FOREVER	Arms stretched up high	Jesus is coming back to make everything new.

2. The 12 Phases (One per Month)

The program runs 12 months. It can start in any month. If you start in January, use the "Suggested month" column.

Phase	Suggested month	Title	Books (count)	Running total	Bible section
1	January	In the Beginning	How the Bible works + Genesis (1)	1	Law
2	February	Freedom & God's Good Rules	Exodus–Deuteronomy (4)	5	Law ✅
3	March	Into the Promised Land	Joshua, Judges, Ruth (3)	8	History
4	April	Kings & Kingdoms	1 Samuel–2 Chronicles (6)	14	History
5	May	Coming Home & Being Brave	Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther (3)	17	History ✅
6	June	Songs & Wise Words	Job–Song of Songs (5)	22	Poetry & Wisdom ✅
7	July	God's Big Messengers	Isaiah–Daniel (5)	27	Major Prophets ✅
8	August	Twelve Mighty Messengers	Hosea–Malachi (12)	39	Minor Prophets ✅ **Old Testament complete!**
9	September	Meet Jesus!	Matthew, Mark, Luke, John (4)	43	Gospels ✅
10	October	The Church Is Born	Acts (1)	44	History (NT) ✅
11	November	Letters from Paul	Romans–Philemon (13)	57	Paul's Letters ✅
12	December	Faith, Hope & Forever	Hebrews–Revelation (9)	66	General Letters + Prophecy ✅ **Whole Bible!**

> **Tip:** Phase 12 lands in December in the suggested calendar, so the final "Bible Bowl" and graduation celebration can be part of your Christmas program.

3. Age Groups

Every lesson is written for one shared Bible story, taught at four levels. With a small church you can combine groups (see "Small Church Setup" below).

Group	Ages	Grades (approx.)	How they learn	What "mastery" looks like by year end
🐑 **Little Lambs**	4–6	Pre-K – K	Pictures, songs, hand motions, coloring, short stories, repeat-after-me	Sing the books song with motions; name the 10 sections; recognize the first letter of many books; tell 12 Bible stories in their own words

Group	Ages	Grades (approx.)	How they learn	What "mastery" looks like by year end
🧭 **Explorers**	7–10	1st – 4th	Stories, simple trivia, games, reading short verses, spelling	Say **and spell** all 66 books in order; find any book in their Bible; one-sentence summary of key books
🥾 **Trailblazers**	11–13	5th – 7th	"Why" questions, maps, timelines, looking up verses, teamwork	Say all 66 in order with sections; one-sentence summary of **every** book; place major people on a timeline
🕊️ **Ambassadors**	14–17	8th – 12th	Big themes, worldview and apologetics, real-life application, leading others	Everything above, plus explain how each section points to Jesus; lead a younger group's game or memory drill; give a 2-minute overview of the whole Bible

Ambassadors as helpers: Teens are invited to serve as "Junior Leaders" for one rotation (game, memory drill or craft) in a younger room at least once per month. This builds leadership and reinforces their own learning.

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4. The Weekly Session (75 minutes)

Every Sunday follows the same rhythm, so kids know what to expect and volunteers can step in easily. A printable version is in weekly-session-template.md.

Time	Segment	What happens
0:00–0:10	🎵 **Welcome & Book Chant**	Greet kids by name, take attendance, sing the cumulative Books of the Bible song with motions
0:10–0:25	📖 **Bible Story / Lesson**	Object-lesson hook + story script (from the phase file)
0:25–0:35	📺 **Video**	One video from @SharefaithKids, @BibleJourneyTV or @bibleproject, chosen by age group
0:35–0:45	💬 **Small-Group Questions**	Age-specific discussion questions
0:45–0:55	🎮 **Game**	An active game that reinforces book names or the story
0:55–1:10	🖍️ **Activity / Coloring / Craft**	Coloring page, craft, word puzzle or trivia
1:10–1:15	✅ **Memory & Spelling Check + Prayer**	Quick check-offs, Bible Passport stickers, closing prayer

Shorter service? (45-minute version): Chant (5) → Story (10) → Video (8) → Questions (7) → Game *or* Craft (10) → Check + Prayer (5).

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5. Monthly Rhythm (Inside Each Phase)

Week	Focus
Week 1	Introduce the phase: Big Idea, new books, new song verse, first story
Week 2	Story 2: add motions, spelling list goes home
Week 3	Story 3: trivia warm-up, spelling relay
Week 4	Story 4 + **End-of-Phase Review**: check-offs, Bible Passport stamp, phase badge
Week 5 (if the month has one)	**Review & Fun Sunday**: big review game, catch-up check-offs, celebration snack

6. Recognition System

- 🛂 **Bible Passport:** Each child gets a passport booklet (see printables). They earn a stamp or sticker for each phase completed.
- 🏅 **Phase Badges:** 12 badges, one per phase (described in each phase file). Use stickers, pins or iron-on patches on a lanyard or sash.
- ⭐ **Weekly Stars:** Stars for attendance, bringing a Bible, saying the memory verse, and spelling check-off.
- 🎓 **Year-End Graduation:** Certificates by level ("Bible Explorer," "66 Books Champion," etc.) at the Phase 12 celebration.

Fairness rule: Every child can earn every badge. Mastery is measured *against their own age level*, and teachers may adapt for learning differences. Effort counts.

7. Staffing

Role	Count	Responsibilities
Children's Ministry Director	1	Oversees program, schedules volunteers, orders supplies, communicates with parents
Lead Teacher (per room)	1 per age group	Teaches story, leads discussion
Assistant / Helper	1+ per room	Attendance, crafts, check-offs, bathroom escorts
Media Helper	1 (shared)	Queues videos, manages screens and sound
Junior Leaders (Ambassadors)	Rotating	Lead games and memory drills in younger rooms

Safety: Follow Purpose Church's child safety policy: background-checked adults, two-adult rule, check-in and check-out, allergy list posted in each room.

Small Church Setup

- **2 rooms:** Room A = Little Lambs + Explorers (ages 4–10); Room B = Trailblazers + Ambassadors (ages 11–17).
- **1 room:** Teach the story together, then split tables by age for questions and activities. Ambassadors lead the younger tables.

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8. Recommended Bibles & Resources

Group	Recommended Bible
Little Lambs	A picture story Bible (e.g., *The Jesus Storybook Bible*, *The Beginner's Bible*) plus an NIrV for reading verses together
Explorers	NIrV (New International Reader's Version) or ICB
Trailblazers	NIV or NLT
Ambassadors	NIV, NLT, ESV or CSB, ideally a study Bible

Every phase file quotes memory verses from the NIV. Swap in your church's preferred translation if you like.

YouTube channels used all year: @SharefaithKids, @BibleJourneyTV and @bibleproject. See the YouTube Video Guide.

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9. Folder Map

```
sunday-school-curriculum/
├── README.md                          ← start here
├── 00-start-here/
│   ├── program-overview.md            ← this file
│   ├── teacher-training-guide.md      ← how to teach, run games, trivia & spelling
│   ├── weekly-session-template.md     ← printable Sunday plan
│   ├── books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md  ← how kids memorize, spell & read all 66 books
│   ├── game-library.md                ← reusable games for any phase
│   ├── youtube-video-guide.md         ← how to use the 3 YouTube channels
│   ├── supply-list.md                 ← what to buy
│   └── parent-welcome-letter.md       ← send home on Day 1
├── phases/                            ← 12 monthly phase guides
└── printables/                        ← coloring sheets, word searches, flashcards,
passport
```